

Your First Legal Steps to Start a Business

Turning an idea into a real business starts with a few key legal steps. Do these right and you protect yourself, look professional, and open the door to funding. Below are the official, mostly-free national resources. Tick the box once you've done each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

You don't need to pay a pricey service for most of this — the government sites below let you do it yourself for free or cheap. Watch out for sites that charge big fees for an EIN, which is always free from the IRS.

1 Plan Before You Register

A simple plan and the right structure save money and headaches later.

☐ SBA — Write Your Business Plan

Free templates and step-by-step guidance to plan your business.

→ www.sba.gov/business-guide/plan-your-business/write-your-business-plan

☐ SBA — Choose a Business Structure

Compare LLC, sole proprietor, corporation, and more — it affects taxes and liability.

→ www.sba.gov/business-guide/launch-your-business/choose-business-structure

2 Register Your Business

Make it official with your state and get your free federal tax ID.

☐ Register With Your State

Most businesses register with the state. SBA links you to your state's office.

→ www.sba.gov/business-guide/launch-your-business/register-your-business

☐ Get Your EIN — Free From the IRS

Your federal tax ID. It's always free directly from the IRS — never pay for one.

→ www.irs.gov/businesses/small-businesses-self-employed/apply-for-an-employer-identification-number-ein-online

3 Licenses, Permits & Taxes

Make sure you're allowed to operate and set up to pay taxes correctly.

☐ Find Licenses & Permits

SBA helps you find the federal, state, and local licenses your business needs.

→ www.sba.gov/business-guide/launch-your-business/apply-licenses-permits

☐ Understand Your Business Taxes

IRS guide to which taxes apply and how to set up to pay them.

→ www.irs.gov/businesses/small-businesses-self-employed

4 Get Free Expert Help

Free, experienced mentors and advisors guide you through every step.

☐ SCORE — Free Business Mentoring

Free one-on-one mentoring from experienced business people.

→ www.score.org

☐ Small Business Development Center (SBDC)

Free local advising on planning, registering, and funding your business.

→ www.sba.gov/local-assistance/resource-partners/small-business-development-centers-sbdc

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Never pay a website for an EIN — it's free at IRS.gov. Be cautious of services charging hundreds to "register" your business when your state lets you do it directly for a small fee.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Before spending a dollar, book a free session with SCORE or your local SBDC. They'll help you avoid costly mistakes and may know grants and loans you qualify for.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national steps. For your state's exact registration, licenses, and local advisors, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll point you to the right offices.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
